



Olympic gold medallist shooter Abhinav Bindra (centre) in conversation with Raveendran Sankaran, DG of the Bihar State Sports Authority, and Sportstar Editor Ayon Sengupta at the Sportstar Focus Bihar Conclave in Patna. R.V. MOORTHY

aspect; we look at failure in a very poor way. It is all about success. If you win, you are good. If you fail, you are useless. Our relationship with failure needs work. It has to be about letting go of the unwanted baggage and learning from each event. Because most athletes will fail. And there comes another point; we have come at a stage where more athletes are going to participate in sports. It is wonderful to see that. But that means more young people are going to fail in sport. So what are you going to do? So, a robust school and university system, a dual career, education are an absolute must. Right now, put everything on the line. I understand why it is that way. For a lot of them, it is a way to better life. But if we give them a chance to build some other skill, it may take longer, they will build some capacity for life after sport. This will build sporting success as well. The mindset is not just the athlete, it is also the human, if you put everything on the line you are not going to be balanced. When athletes fail, they have something to fall back onto.

Can India have a unified pipeline for talent instead of fragmented schemes like Khelo India?

It is an opportunity. Sport is always developed in silos in India. It has the potential to draw unified effort where priorities are set in place and everyone has to follow that. India has 30 odd States and every State is almost like a country. Sport is a State matter and it eventually comes down to that in how we develop sport. Maybe every State can adopt a sport but that will be challenging. Suppose, if Bihar picks shooting, but then what happens to shooters in Tamil Nadu or Telangana? Do they move to Bihar to develop further?

I believe there can be centres of excellence at some places. I believe that the role that different governments play is immense. It cannot, however, be about one or two sports. If we stick to the sports we are good at, we are not winning more than 15 medals. But if the aspiration is to win 50 medals, then we need to win at swimming, rowing, athletics, and so on. How do we achieve that is the question. Every

government has to play a role in that.

How do you look back on your sporting career without the gold medal?

My worth is not dependant on that gold medal. I think is not the only aspect about me. I do not look back at my years in sport, I do not look back at that gold medal I won or the others that hang on my wall. I look back at the relationships I was able to build through sports, with my family, with my coaches, with competitors. I look back at what sports taught. It taught me a thing or two about winning and about losing, respecting outcomes and competitors and most importantly myself, dealing with internal conflict. Sport has given me some many memories and lessons. That left me in good stead to face the greater test called life.

The Sportstar 'Focus Bihar' Conclave is presented by the Bihar Sports Authority and Department of Sports, Government of Bihar. The Associate Sponsor is Indian Oil Corporation Limited, while State Bank of India is the Banking Partner.